

TIME TO SING THE REDEMPTION SONG

The shorter Olympic cycle due to **COVID** may contribute to the lingering memory of the Tokyo debacle. However, Indian shooters have a chance at redemption in Paris.

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In about six months, the curtain rises for the ultimate spectacle in France. The final act of Indian shooting's redemption arc, where 340 of the world's best descend onto Chateauroux for the final boss battle.

The COVID-induced shorter Olympic cycle may be a reason why the memories of the Tokyo debacle seem fresh like it happened only yesterday. While the takeaways from most sports were largely positive, the shooters were left red-faced. They had come back empty-handed, even though India was able to send 15 shooters, its largest-ever Olympic contingent, to the Japanese capital.

The following years were bittersweet. Amid multiple rule changes and coaching setup overhauls, among other developments, a few names disappeared from scorecards for various reasons. Saurabh Chaudhary, Abhishek Verma, Apurvi Chandela, and Rahi Sarnobat are not household names anymore. The likes of Esha

Singh, Rudranksh Balasaheb Patil, Sift Kaur Samra, Sarabjot Singh, Tilottama Sen, and Ashi Chouksey took over.

Shooters like Manu Bhaker and Divyansh Singh Panwar went into recovery mode, with the media hullabaloo having exacted a heavy toll. But the duo seems to have returned to the scheme of things just in time.

The Hangzhou high

If the Asian Games numbers are anything to go by, the shooters are in a much better place. However, one has to keep in mind that 11 of Hangzhou's 22 medals came from same-gender team events, a privilege the shooters won't have at the Summer Games. So, there will not be any room for complacency.

There was that singular moment of genius, though. One that would rank very high even if achievements across all sports in 2023 are taken into account. It was the individual world record set in Hangzhou by Sift. In an exhilarating finish to the women's 50m rifle 3 positions final, the 22-year-old notched up 469.6 after taking 15 shots each in the kneeling, prone, and standing

positions. Her mark was a considerable upgrade — 2.6 points — over the previous world record held by British star Seonaid McIntosh. China's Qiongyue Zhang, the eventual silver medallist, finished 7.3 points behind!

Memorable moments

There were other performances as well that would be remembered for a long time to come. India started 2023 on a high, topping the medal charts at the Cairo World Cup in February. The country won seven medals (four gold and three bronze), with second-placed Hungary only managing three (two gold and one silver). Aishwary Pratap Singh Tomar and Rudranksh brought out their A-game.

The stakes rose when archrival China entered the fray at the Bhopal World Cup. It was the first time the city was playing host to an ISSF championship, having built a new final hall at the Madhya Pradesh State Shooting Academy.

Sarabjot (10m air pistol) may have won India's only gold medal of the competition, but Bhaker stole the spotlight when she struck bronze, her first ISSF World Cup medal in